QP CODE 25900433

MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025

Third SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG3DSCHIS200 - SOCIETY IN PRE- MODERN KERALA

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

Part A

SHORT ANSWER

Answer any **10** questions Each question carries **2** marks

1. **Anantavarahan** - Gold coins- Issued by the Travancore rulers- Anantharaman Panam' and 'Ananthavarahan Panam'.
2. **Palm- leaf manuscripts**-made out of dried palm leaves- used to recording royal edicts, temple records, land grants, literature, and religious texts- written mainly in Malayalam, Tamil, or Sanskrit- vital historical sources that reveal Kerala's administration, culture, and knowledge system
3. **Pattanam -** Located near North Paravur in Ernakulam district- important archaeological site in pre-modern Kerala- believed to be the ancient port of Muziris (Muchiri)**,** a major centre of Indo-Roman trade mentioned in Sangam literature and Greco-Roman writings**.**
4. **Megalith- Mega** means *large* and lithos means *stone-Megalith means large stone monuments-used for burial purposes* - Common types include dolmens, cists, umbrella stones (Kodakkal) etc.
5. **Karalar**- landholders or local chieftains- controlled and managed agricultural lands- they played an important role in the village administration and agrarian system.
6. **Pulavar** – agricultural laboureres- specialized in certain category of skilled and unskilled jobs (value liberally)
7. **Koyiladhikarikal**- temple authorities or officials who managed the affairs of temples- responsible for administration, rituals, and collection of temple revenues.
8. **Vaishnavism** - developed along with the Bhakti movement- worshipped Lord Vishnu and his incarnations like Rama and Krishna- alvars were devotees of Lord Vishnu.
9. **Uzhiyam**- free labour or compulsory service-especially those belonging to lower castes or landless workers.
10. **Perumals Decline**- internal conflicts, rise of powerful local chieftains (Naduvazhis), and the weakening of central authority - growing independence of temple authorities and Brahmin settlements (Brahmadeyams) also reduced royal control.

11. **Arunnattuvar** – temple management authorities during the Brahmin supremacy in Kerala - local administrative officers or officials who worked under the Perumals or Naduvazhis (local chieftains)
12. **Purayitam**- low-lying agricultural land or wetland used mainly for paddy cultivation- household and agricultural land together in a place.

Part B

SHORT ESSAY

Answer any 6 questions Each question carries 5 marks

13. Discuss the literary sources on the history of Kerala - Sangam literature -earliest reference to Chera kings and trade-Keralolpathi -origin legend of Kerala and Brahmin settlements - Unnuneelisandesam and Manipravalam poems - Temple inscriptions and copper plates record land grants- Foreign accounts -Travelogues by Ibn Battuta and Duarte Barbosa.

14. Analyze the level of technological and architectural skill required to create the different types of megaliths in Kerala- Cists, Dolmens, Urns, Menhirs, Rock-Cut Tombs- Accurate stone cutting and shaping without iron tools- Alignment and orientation show planning skill-Underground chambers need engineering knowledge-Transportation of large slabs shows organized labor-Burial goods reflect metal-working and craft skills- Regional variation indicates experimentation.

15. Explain the evolution of tenurial relations in ancient Kerala- Early communal land ownership under clan chiefs- Gradual privatization with settled agriculture-

Rise of Brahmadeyam villages -Devaswam lands- Janmi–Kanam system-Agrarian hierarchy became rigidly caste-based-Tenurial system supported temple economy-Continued influence till colonial land reforms.

16. Discuss the role of Nadu-level institutions in integrating agriculture with polity and society-Nadu -cluster of villages forming a political unit- Headed by Naduvazhi or local chief-Coordination of agricultural activities and irrigation-Supervised tax collection and land distribution-Ur-Temples acted as economic centers- Political, social, and economic life interconnected-Maintained local law and order-Strengthened regional identity and state formation.

17. Explain the role of fishing and hunting in Tinai economy-Ecological region-Neytal Tinai-coastal zone dependent on fishing- Palai-Mullai-hunting and gathering activities-Provided protein and trade commodities -Fish, Meat-Subsistence base for non-agricultural groups-Seasonal occupation tied to nature cycles-Cultural rituals linked with sea and forest deities-Supported maritime trade through fish exports- ecological adaptation.

18. Explain the role of major ports like Muziris and Kollam in overseas trade of premodern Kerala-Muziris -major port of ancient Cheras-Linked Kerala with Rome, Arabia, and Egypt-Exported pepper, pearls, ivory, timber- Imported gold, wine, glass, and textiles-Kollam -After

Muziris decline- Center of Arab, Chinese, and Southeast Asian trade- Brought wealth and cosmopolitan culture.

19. Explain the early spread of Islam through Arab traders on the Malabar coast-Pre-existing Arab trade contacts before Islam-Muslim traders arrived by 7th century CE- Peaceful propagation through commerce-Cheraman Juma Masjid- Local rulers welcomed Arab settlers-Inter-marriages with local women-Mappila Muslim community-Mosques became centers of faith and trade-Islam integrated into Kerala's plural society.

20. Examine the relationship between the Swaroopams and the powerful Nair aristocracy-Ruling lineage-royal house-Perumpadappu, Nediyiruppu, Venad-Nairs formed military and administrative class-Hereditary service ties between kings and Nairs- Nairs controlled local governance and defense-Received land and titles for service- Maintained caste and political order-Basis of Kerala's feudal political system.

21. Analyze the role of powerful local rulers in both facilitating and regulating trade-Chera, Zamorin, Venad kings-patronized trade-Maintained port facilities and customs offices-protection to merchants and ships- copper plates-Anjuvannam, Manigramam-Ports became centres of urban growth-Controlled trade ensured both profit and stability.

22. How did caste-based occupations affect the social status of men and women in pre-modern Kerala- Occupation determined by hereditary caste-Brahmins-ritual and land control- Nairs - military and administrative duties-Artisan and service castes - productive labor- Lower castes – agriculture, fishing, manual work Occupation defined purity–pollution hierarchy- strict social rules-Women's roles confined within caste norms-Economic inequality reflected in social ranking-Caste occupation reinforced rigid social structure.

Part C

ESSAY QUESTION

Answer any 2 questions Each question carries 10 marks

23. **Discuss the influence of Kerala's topography on its human settlements.** Narrow coastal strip – The long coastline encouraged fishing, trade, and port-based settlements (like Muziris, Kollam, Kozhikode)- Western Ghats barrier – The mountain ranges limited inland expansion but provided spices, forest products, and protection from invasions-Rivers and backwaters – Numerous rivers and waterways supported agriculture, transport, and dense settlements in fertile valleys-Fertile plains – The midland and coastal plains enabled wet-rice cultivation, leading to clustered agrarian villages-Highland and forest zones – Sparsely populated; inhabited mainly by Adivasi and tribal communities engaged in shifting cultivation and hunting-Climate and rainfall – Heavy monsoons shaped housing styles (sloped roofs, raised platforms) and seasonal agricultural patterns.

24. **Assess how caste formation and regional identity were shaped by monarchichal and brahmanical dominance in early kerala.** - Monarchical rise – Local chieftains (naduvazhis, desavazhis) and Chera rulers built hierarchical polities seeking ritual legitimacy-Brahmin migration – Arrival of Namboothiri Brahmins (7th–9th c. CE) introduced varna ideology to Kerala-Temple centered economy – Kings granted brahmadeyam lands to Brahmins, making temples economic and social hubs – Mutual support: kings gained divine authority, Brahmins gained land and power-Caste formation – Society structured into rigid hierarchy: Brahmins, Nairs/Kshatriyas, Ezhavas, Pulayas, etc - Ritual purity & pollution – Unique Kerala system of untouchability and unapproachability reinforced caste divisions. Land control – Brahmins and elites-controlled land; lower castes tied to agrarian labor and servitude– Local deities and customs merged with Brahmanical worship, shaping a distinct regional culture-Language & identity

25**. Analyse the role of temples as centers of redistribution and economic integration**-Land grants (Devadana/Brahmadeyam) – Temples owned vast lands donated by kings and elites-Agrarian control – Managed cultivation, collected produce, and organized local labour-Redistribution of wealth – Distributed grains, wages, and offerings to priests, workers, and poor-Employment hub – Provided work to priests, artisans, dancers, cleaners, guards, etc-Temple economy – Functioned as centres of production, storage, and exchange-Market growth – Stimulated local trade and craft industries around temple towns -Social integration – Linked different castes, occupations, and regions through shared economic activity– Temples reflected royal patronage and helped integrate local polities -Cultural centre – Promoted art, music, and education, uniting society through religion and economy.

26. **Critically analyse the trial and ordeal system as a reflection of socio-religious life in medieval Kerala**. Types of ordeals – Common methods included fire ordeal (Thee-divyam), water ordeal (Jala-divyam), poison test, and touching sacred objects to prove truthfulness-Brahmanical influence – Brahmins often conducted and supervised ordeals, linking justice with ritual purity and Vedic authority-Social hierarchy – The system favoured upper castes who had access to temple rituals; lower castes faced harsher or humiliating ordeals-Gender dimension – Women, especially in cases of adultery or chastity, were often subjected to trial by fire or water, showing patriarchal bias-Absence of rational evidence – Judgments depended on faith and ritual, not on factual or legal reasoning — showing a pre-modern moral order-Reflection of socio-religious life – Reveals how law, religion, and caste were deeply intertwined; justice was seen as a sacred, not secular, process-Critical view – Though it reflected religious faith and social order, it also reinforced inequality, superstition, and priestly dominance, eventually replaced by rational legal systems under colonial rule.

[2x10 = 20]